spending $261 billion in 2016.[17] From nearly every perspective, America's China bet paid off in spades: China, the "middle country," sits firmly at the center of today's globalized world.

Perhaps having been transfixed by their own beliefs, liberal nations are now disappointed and surprised that a China that has reached the heights of global power is increasingly refusing to play by the global script expected of it. While Beijing has eagerly taken advantage of access to the global economy and the prestige of sitting at the leading diplomatic tables, it has resolutely pursued its own interests, regardless of the impact on other nations, and shown far less concern for becoming a steward of the system that enriched it. It is becoming increasingly clear that American policy makers undervalued the resiliency of China's national interests and the power of the CCP, misunderstood Chinese history, and underestimated Beijing's intention to become not merely a leading but a dominant global power, an aspiration that now concerns Washington as much as did Japan's far less comprehensive challenge in the 1980s.

More realistic international observers are not surprised that as China has become more powerful it has shown increasing dissatisfaction with the rules and structures of the very international system that allowed it to rise, undermining norms and attempting to change some of the practices of global governance. At the same time, it shows no qualms in either invoking or disregarding international law to buttress its trade policies or claims over disputed territory in areas such as the South China Sea. Washington and other liberal capitals misjudged Beijing's determination to maintain, protect, and even expand its authoritarian tendencies and mercantilist policies. Far from liberalizing, as Western policy makers and pundits hoped and assumed, the CCP at the end of the second decade of the twenty-first century is increasing its tight control of civil society and freedom of association and expression at home, while at the same time engaging intensively and often overbearingly with the outside world.

After two decades of opening up under Deng Xiaoping and Jiang Zemin, marked most notably by significant economic reform and the